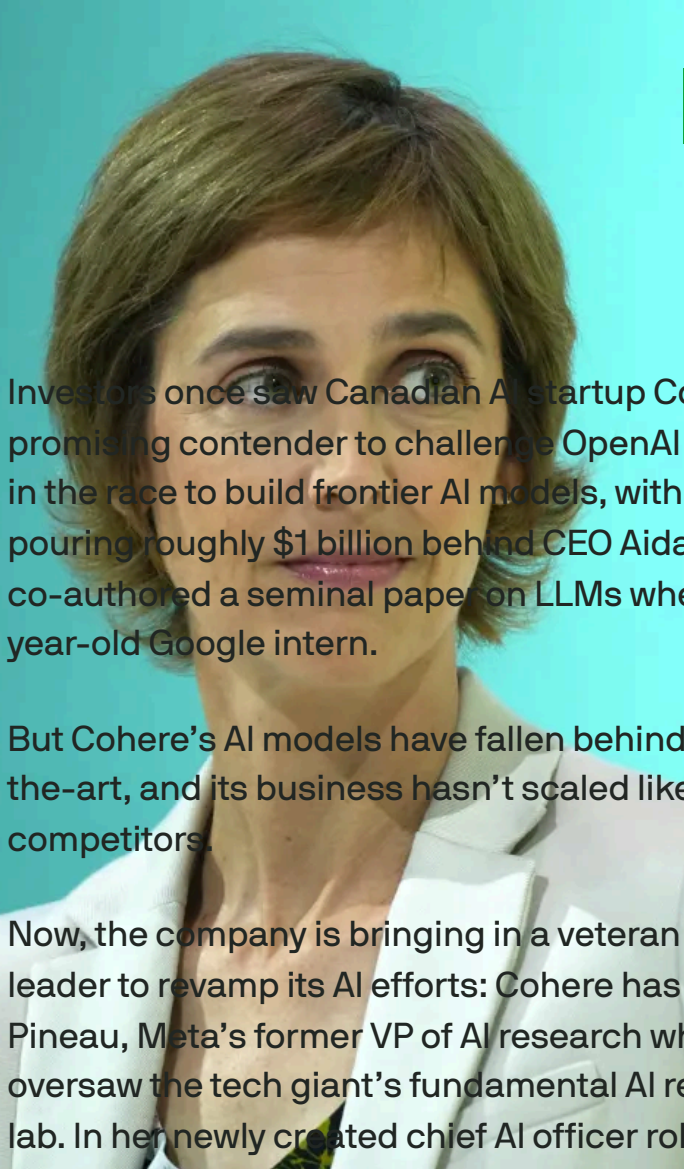

AI



**Cohere hires long-time
Meta research head Joelle
Pineau as its chief AI
officer**



Investors once saw Canadian AI startup Cohere as a promising contender to challenge OpenAI and Anthropic in the race to build frontier AI models, with its backers pouring roughly \$1 billion behind CEO Aidan Gomez, who co-authored a seminal paper on LLMs when he was a 20-year-old Google intern.

But Cohere's AI models have fallen behind the state-of-the-art, and its business hasn't scaled like its competitors.

Now, the company is bringing in a veteran research leader to revamp its AI efforts: Cohere has hired Joelle Pineau, Meta's former VP of AI research who previously oversaw the tech giant's fundamental AI research (FAIR) lab. In her newly created chief AI officer role, Pineau will oversee AI strategy across Cohere's research, product, and policy teams.

NATHAN LATNE/BLOOMBERG / GETTY IMAGES

A Canadian AI scientist and McGill professor, Pineau helped guide the early development of Meta's open Llama AI models alongside Yann LeCun, a pioneer of neural networks. Pineau [left Meta](#) in May after nearly eight years with the company.

For Cohere this is a big hire, and it is pinning its hopes on the veteran helping it with more research breakthroughs, improving its research and product pipeline, and recruiting top talent.

The hire comes at a pivotal moment for Cohere: The company just raised \$500 million at a [\\$6.8 billion valuation](#) — an impressive sum were the startup not competing with the likes of OpenAI, Google, Meta, and Anthropic, whose war chests are worth dozens of billions each.



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But while its rivals are trying to develop AI systems that can match (or exceed) human performance on a wide variety of tasks, Cohere has a narrower focus. The startup primarily builds AI applications that can solve practical problems for enterprises and government agencies, emphasizing privacy and security.

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In an interview with TechCrunch, Pineau said Cohere's focus on real-world enterprise applications is something she's excited about. "A lot of players out there are quite singularly focused on AGI, superintelligence, and so on," said Pineau, alluding to companies like her former employer, Meta, which recently invested billions in its new Meta Superintelligence Labs (MSL) unit. "They haven't necessarily figured out what this AI is going to be used for."

She pointed to OpenAI's [launch of GPT-5](#) last week, which many felt was underwhelming, as evidence the timeline to achieving AGI may be "a little bit longer than we thought." In the meantime, Pineau says there's a lot of room for more practical AI models to deliver leaps in productivity in different industries.

A Canada native, Pineau said she's had her eye on Cohere since they were founded in 2019, and that she's excited to

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contribute to a company whose founders are based in her home country.



JOELLE PINEAU

IMAGE CREDITS: PAUL MORIGI/HADDAD MEDIA / GETTY IMAGES

Beyond the patriotism, Pineau feels the opportunity with Cohere is a good chance to venture beyond research. At FAIR, Pineau oversaw research teams working on projects that could take anywhere from 18 months to 10 years to deliver. Now, she'll be working within a much tighter timeline, as well as getting involved with customers and products. And even though Cohere has fewer resources than Meta, Pineau said she'll be more agile in her new role.

Cohere's latest product is an AI agent [platform dubbed North](#) that enterprises and government agencies can deploy privately on their own infrastructure, an attractive notion for many of its customers, which are banks and federal organizations that handle highly sensitive data. That puts Cohere in competition with open source providers like DeepSeek and Meta, whose models can also be run locally, but at a lower cost. Cohere is betting that by offering more support around its private deployments, it can beat out open models.

Pineau said she's particularly interested in gearing more of Cohere's research around North, figuring out ways to develop AI agents in private and secure settings, and creating benchmarks to evaluate these systems. Pineau

also said she's interested in exploring how networks of AI agents interact with each other in the real world.

One immediate challenge for Pineau will be replacing Cohere's VP of AI Research, Sara Hooker, who announced her [departure](#) this week after several years of helping build the company's research program. Hiring an AI researcher of Hooker's caliber may be difficult in the current market given the skyrocketing demand for AI talent.

But Pineau sees this as an opportunity to "bring in a lot of talent," noting that when she left Meta, several of her former colleagues suggested they'd follow her to a new AI lab. However, she emphasized that Cohere has a solid base of AI researchers, and that it's important to not just bring in anyone.

"Hiring a bunch of superstars doesn't necessarily make a superstar team," said Pineau. "It's really about how the people work together."

Of course, Meta's AI units today look very different compared with when Pineau was there just a few months ago. Over the summer, Mark Zuckerberg went on a [recruiting spree](#), reportedly offering some of the industry's best AI researchers compensation packages north of \$100 million to join MSL. That prompted OpenAI to also raise compensation for its star employees, thus making it quite difficult for smaller players to land top AI researchers.

As Meta, OpenAI, and Anthropic throw billions of dollars at their AI efforts, Cohere is trying to do more with less. For Pineau, that will mean making calculated research bets — the kind that can quickly turn into compelling products and keep the company in the race.

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Texas attorney general
accuses Meta,
Character.AI of misleading

kids with mental health claims

Rebecca Bellan — 10:59 AM PDT · August 18, 2025



Texas attorney general Ken Paxton has launched an investigation into both Meta AI Studio and Character.AI for “potentially engaging in deceptive trade practices and misleadingly marketing themselves as mental health tools,” according to a [press release](#) issued Monday.

“In today’s digital age, we must continue to fight to protect Texas kids from deceptive and exploitative technology,” Paxton is quoted as saying. “By posing as sources of emotional support, AI platforms can mislead vulnerable users, especially children, into believing they’re receiving legitimate mental health care. In reality, they’re often being fed recycled, generic responses engineered to align with harvested personal data and disguised as therapeutic advice.”

IMAGE CREDITS: GETTY IMAGES

The probe comes a few days after [Senator Josh Hawley announced an investigation into Meta](#) following a report that found its AI chatbots were interacting inappropriately with children, including by flirting.

The Texas Attorney General’s office has accused Meta and [Character.AI](#) of creating AI personas that present as “professional therapeutic tools, despite lacking proper medical credentials or oversight.”

Among the millions of AI personas available on Character.AI, one user-created bot called [Psychologist](#) has seen high demand among the startup’s young users. Meanwhile, Meta doesn’t offer therapy bots for kids, but there’s nothing stopping children from using the Meta AI

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chatbot or one of the personas created by third parties for therapeutic purposes.

“We clearly label AIs, and to help people better understand their limitations, we include a disclaimer that responses are generated by AI — not people,” Meta spokesperson Ryan Daniels told TechCrunch. “These AIs aren’t licensed professionals and our models are designed to direct users to seek qualified medical or safety professionals when appropriate.”

However, TechCrunch noted that many children may not understand — or may simply ignore — such disclaimers. We have asked Meta what additional safeguards it takes to protect minors using its chatbots.



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For its part, Character includes prominent disclaimers in every chat to remind users that a “Character” is not a real person, and everything they say should be treated as fiction, according to a Character.AI spokesperson. She noted that the startup adds additional disclaimers when users create Characters with the words “psychologist,” “therapist,” or “doctor” to not rely on them for any type of professional advice.

In his statement, Paxton also observed that though AI chatbots assert confidentiality, their “terms of service

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reveal that user interactions are logged, tracked, and exploited for targeted advertising and algorithmic development, raising serious concerns about privacy violations, data abuse, and false advertising.”

According to [Meta’s privacy policy](#), Meta does collect prompts, feedback, and other interactions with AI chatbots and across Meta services to “improve AIs and related technology.” The policy doesn’t explicitly say anything about advertising, but it does state that information can be shared with third parties, like search engines, for “more personalized outputs.” Given Meta’s ad-based business model, this effectively translates to targeted advertising.

Character.AI’s [privacy policy](#) also highlights how the startup logs identifiers, demographics, location information, and more information about the user, including browsing behavior and app usage platforms. It tracks users across ads on TikTok, YouTube, Reddit, Facebook, Instagram, and Discord, which it may link to a user’s account. This information is used to train AI, tailor the service to personal preferences, and provide targeted advertising, including sharing data with advertisers and analytics providers.

A Character.AI spokesperson said the startup is “just beginning to explore targeted advertising on the platform” and that those explorations “have not involved using the content of chats on the platform.”

The spokesperson also confirmed that the same privacy policy applies to all users, even teenagers.

TechCrunch has asked Meta such tracking is done on children, too, and will update this story if we hear back.

Both Meta and Character say their services aren’t designed for children under 13. That said, Meta has come under fire for failing to police accounts created by kids under 13, and Character’s kid-friendly characters are clearly designed to attract younger users. The startup’s CEO, Karandeep Anand, has even said that his [six-year-old daughter](#) uses the platform’s chatbots under his supervision.

That type of data collection, targeted advertising, and algorithmic exploitation is exactly what legislation like KOSA (Kids Online Safety Act) is meant to protect against. KOSA was teed up to pass last year with strong bipartisan support, but it stalled after major pushback from tech industry lobbyists. Meta in particular deployed a formidable lobbying machine, warning lawmakers that the bill's broad mandates would undercut its business model.

[KOSA was reintroduced](#) to the Senate in May 2025 by Senators Marsha Blackburn (R-TN) and Richard Blumenthal (D-CT).

Paxton has issued civil investigative demands — legal orders that require a company to produce documents, data, or testimony during a government probe — to the companies to determine if they have violated Texas consumer protection laws.

This story was updated with comments from a Character.AI spokesperson.

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IMAGE CREDITS: PARADIGM

STARTUPS



Why Paradigm built a spreadsheet with an AI agent in every cell

Rebecca Szkutak — 8:00 AM PDT · August 18, 2025

Anna Monaco has been building AI agents since before the term “AI agents” was even a thing. After building numerous chatbots, she started looking for other types of interfaces that made sense for AI agents and landed on spreadsheets.

“I had this personal pattern, and I noticed that a lot of other people had this pattern, of putting very important CRM data in spreadsheets just because it was the most flexible thing,” Monaco told TechCrunch. “But it was

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actually a pain to maintain. There's so much manual work involved. So [I] just went down this rabbit hole of building a product for myself and wanted to reimagine what a spreadsheet could look like with the full power of LLMs."

The result was [Paradigm](#), an AI-powered spreadsheet equipped with more than 5,000 AI agents. Users can assign different prompts to individual columns and cells, and individual AI agents will crawl the internet to find and fill out the needed information.

Paradigm works with AI models from Anthropic, OpenAI, and Google's Gemini, Monaco said, and supports model switching.

"We want to support every single model because we want our users to be able to have the highest reasoning outputs when they need it, but also the cheapest outputs," Monaco said. "It's just a constant cycle of evaluating different models, working closely with model providers to make sure our limits are high enough, and then giving some of that power to our users."

The company launched a small closed beta preview in late 2024 and has been iterating on the product using customer feedback. Paradigm attracts users ranging from consultants to sales professionals and finance folks and operates on a subscription model with tiers based on usage. Paradigm counts the consulting firm EY, AI chip startup Etched, and AI coding company Cognition as early customers.

Paradigm is now releasing its product to the public and announcing that it raised a \$5 million seed round led by General Catalyst. The company has raised \$7 million to date. Monaco said the funding will go toward executing on the company's "extremely aggressive product roadmap."

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“The interesting thing that happened when we fundraised is some people we pitched just kept on using and paying for the product,” Monaco said. “I think that was a cool part of it. We found a lot of value from it internally and our investors, not even just our investors — other investors that we talked to — are still using it.”

Paradigm isn't the only company looking to give spreadsheets an AI upgrade. [Quadratic](#), which has raised more than \$6 million in venture funding, is a 3-year-old startup with a similar goal. Legacy companies like Google and Microsoft are also adding AI tools to their spreadsheet applications.

Monaco said that she doesn't really consider the competition because Paradigm doesn't think of itself as an AI-powered spreadsheet. She said she thinks of it as a new AI-powered workflow that happens to be in the familiar form of a spreadsheet but won't necessarily stay that way forever.

“What I'm seeing in the most popular AI products now is this fine balance between present and future,” Monaco said. “How do you build something that is really powerful and generates a lot of value now but also sets you up really well for the future? That's the question that I asked myself a year ago when I was starting the company.”

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TikTok’s latest feature lets college students find and connect with classmates

In a move reminiscent of Facebook’s early days, TikTok is launching a new feature that allows college students to find and connect with others on their campus. The feature, called Campus Verification, lets users add their college campus to their TikTok profile and browse a list of students at their school.

To access the feature, users need to navigate to their profile and tap the “Add school” button. From there, they need to enter their school name and then select their graduation year.

To verify that they actually go to the school they entered, they need to provide their academic email address. Once complete, their college name and graduation year will be displayed on their profile.

Users can then browse their school’s page, filter by graduation year, and view all of the users who have added the school to their profile. They can also sort the users list to show the most-followed users first.

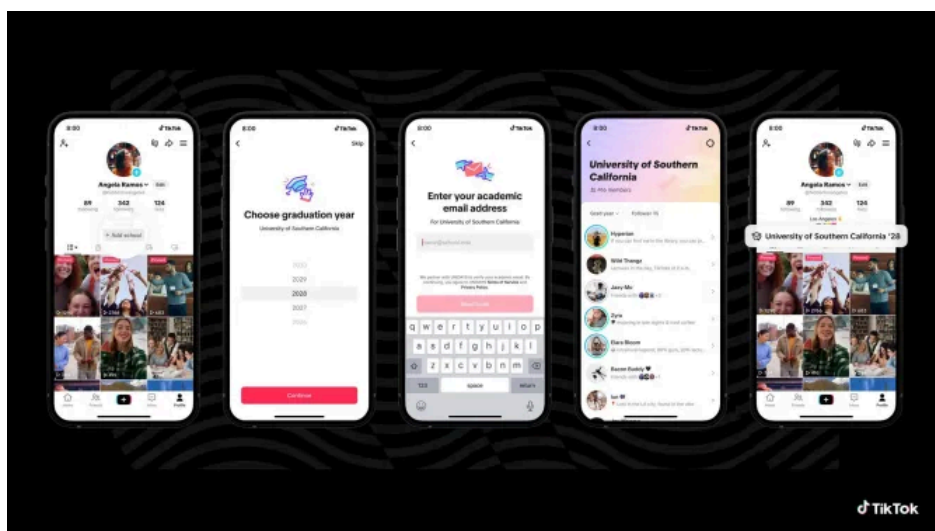


IMAGE CREDITS:TIKTOK

The feature is available across more than 6,000 universities through TikTok’s partnership with [UNiDAYS](#), a student verification platform that confirms student status.

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TikTok says the idea behind the feature is to turn its platform into a hub for real-world connections and belonging on campus, which is essentially what Facebook’s original mission was when it launched in 2004 as a way for Harvard students to connect with one another.

TikTok’s new feature could be a welcome addition for college students looking to connect with others on campus. However, it also raises concerns about digital privacy, as it could make it easier for users to track others online. Of course, the feature is optional, so those who prefer to keep their TikTok presence separate from their student life can choose to simply not add their school to their profile.

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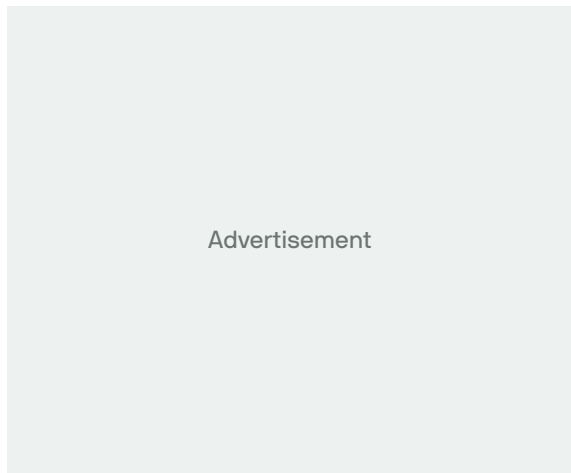
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It’s worth noting that the launch comes as Instagram was [spotted testing a similar feature](#) last year that would allow users to display their school info and graduation year on their profile and connect with other students. It’s unknown if the feature was scrapped or if the Meta-owned platform still plans to roll it out.

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